Currently, Aksu is a city and the seat of Aksu Prefecture, Xinjiang, China. It lies at the northern edge of the Tarim Basin. The name is derived from Turkic Aksu which literally means ‘white water’. This term is used for both the oasis town and the Aksu River. Currently, it is divided into two parts, separated by the Aral city. The northern part hosts the city centre, while the southern part is occupied by the Taklamakan Desert.

According to the primary sources, Aksu was known as Gumo at least from the former Han dynasty (125 BC to AD 23) to the early Tang dynasty (AD 618–907).[*] During the reign of Hams, the kingdom of Gumo comprised 3500 households with a population of around 24,500. Interestingly around 18.3 per cent of the population bore arms. The three major minerals produced were copper, iron and orpiment.[†]

The Buddha Dharma had reached the Chinese Land through India. In that period (when Buddha Dharma reached China) Aksu, was known as Bharuka,[‡] Bohuan and Baluka[§], Bolujia (in Pinyin) and Po-lu-chia (in Wade-Giles). According to the ‘Great Tang Records on the Western Regions’, Xuan Zang referred to the place as Baluka during his visit in AD 629. As per his records, there were tens of Sarvastivadin Buddhist monasteries with more than a thousand monks in the kingdom. He stated the dimensions of the kingdom being 600 li (Chinese Mile) from east to west, and 300 li from north to south. Its capital was said to be six li in circumference. Xuan Zang reported that the ‘native products, climate, temperament of the people, customs, written language and law are the same as in the country of Kuci or modern Kucha’, around 200 miles to the east, ‘but the spoken language is somewhat different’ from the Kuchean language, which is also known as Tocharian B and West Tocharian. He spoke about the export of fine cotton and hemp cloth to the neighbouring country.

The period between the seventh to early ninth centuries saw abundant contest for power. The Chinese Tang Dynasty, the Tibetan Empire and the Uyghur Empire contested to gain control of Aksu. The Tibetan Empire seized Aksu in AD 670, but Tang forces reconquered the region in AD 692. Then we have records that the Tang dynasty in a campaign by Chinese General Tang Jiahui led the Chinese to defeat an Arab-Tibetan attack in the Battle of Aksu (AD 717 AD).[*] On 15 August of AD 717, Uch Turfan and Aksu were attacked by the Turgesh, Arab and Tibetan forces. Qarluqs were serving under the Chinese command. Arsila Xian, a Western Turkic Qaghan was serving under the Chinese Assistant Grand Protector General Tang Jiahui. Together, they defeated the